FOCUS

Solutions: four pillars, four safety nets

No single instrument will suffice. Neither fact-checking, nor media literacy, nor platform moderation can, taken on its own, overcome a phenomenon this multifaceted. Disinformation thrives for three reasons at once:

- **It exploits biases** in how our minds work.
- **It circulates in a digital environment** that favors it.
- **It draws support from social and political vulnerabilities** (economic insecurity, isolation, distrust).

The challenge, then, is no longer simply to **correct falsehoods**, but to **reduce the conditions that make them effective**.

- **The DITP-VIGINUM report.** This is the shift endorsed by the joint report published in 2026 by two French government bodies, the DITP (the interministerial directorate for public transformation) and VIGINUM (the state agency that detects foreign digital interference), to which the author contributed.
- **Layered nets.** Instead of relying solely on correcting false information, the report proposes layering several safety nets.
- **Four pillars.** Here these nets take the form of the four pillars of the policy brief: each catches part of what the others let through.

The four pillars at a glance

How to read the diagram:

- **At the top, disinformation**, seen as the meeting of a *supply* (those who deliberately produce and spread falsehoods, often for political or financial gain) and a *demand* (the social reasons that lead audiences to seek out or believe such content).
- **Below, each pillar is a net.** Its labels show what it targets, how long it takes to show effects, and how solid the supporting studies are.
- **The dots** rate each lever's expected effectiveness.
- **The last line** of each net says what it lets through, or why it is hard to implement.

Disinformation

A strategic supply that meets a social demand

Pillar 1

Drying up the supply of disinformation

Target: supply | Short term | Moderate evidence

Necessary but insufficient. It goes after the revenue and methods of those who spread disinformation (fake accounts, advertising), without the state having to decide what is true.

Demonetize disinformation	●●○○	Make platforms auditable	●○○○
Defend sender authenticity	●●○○*	Regulate AI through its actors	

What slips through: false but legal content produced by domestic actors, which no rule targets; and audiences who go elsewhere for what was removed from a platform.

Pillar 2 Addressing the immediate causes of belief

Target: reception | Short term | Strong evidence

The best-studied levers, but they reach few people. Poorly designed, they mostly teach distrust, and then make people doubt accurate information too.

Refocused media literacy	●●○○	Targeted, repeated prebunking	●●○○
Corrections via credible messengers	●○○○	Sharing frictions	●○○○

What slips through: the most exposed audiences, whom corrections do not reach; and behavior: people learn to judge content better, but this changes less what they share.

Pillar 3 Addressing the deep causes of belief

Target: demand | Long term | Weak to moderate evidence

The most decisive lever and the hardest to pull. Reducing insecurity, isolation and distrust protects against disinformation better than security tools alone: the welfare state is the strongest defense of the sovereign state.

Public integrity	●●●○	Places of social connection	●●●○
Insecurity and benefit non-take-up	●●●○	Depolarization	●○○○*

Why it is hard: slow, costly reforms whose effect on disinformation is the hardest to demonstrate.

Pillar 4

Supporting quality information

Target: the truth | Medium term | Weak to moderate evidence

Fighting for information is often more effective and less costly than fighting against disinformation.

Refinance local news	●●●●	Stable media funding	●●●●
Equip intermediaries	●●●○	Make AI contribute	●●○○*

Why it is neglected: heavy investments whose effects show up at the scale of a territory and a decade, not an election campaign.

CROSS-CUTTING CONDITION

Give ourselves the means to know: measure demand and not just supply, and evaluate whether interventions work. This is the role of the Observatory, presented below.

Expected effectiveness according to the DITP-VIGINUM grid (2026), as used in *La Désinformation* (Darcy, 2026): ●●●● very high, ●●●○ high, ●●○○ moderate, ●○○○ limited; * author's estimate; no dots: lever not rated. The levers are those of the policy brief.

Glossary of levers.

- *Demonetize*: cut off a piece of content's or an account's advertising revenue.
- *Auditable platforms*: platforms whose data and algorithms researchers and regulators can check.
- *Sender authenticity*: verifying who is speaking (tracking fake accounts, tracing where content comes from) rather than judging what is said.
- *Prebunking*: warning people in advance about manipulation techniques, like a vaccine.
- *Credible messengers*: people the target audience already trusts.
- *Sharing frictions*: a short pause before resharing (one more click, a question about reliability).
- *Public integrity*: the exemplary conduct and transparency of institutions, on which their credibility rests.
- *Non-take-up*: not claiming a social benefit one is entitled to.
- *Depolarization*: reducing hostility between political camps.
- *Intermediaries* (pillar 4): fact-checkers and other producers of reliable information.

WHY A SINGLE PILLAR IS NOT ENOUGH

Pillar 2 is the most visible and the best evaluated, but correction can intercept only part of the content. Attack holds a structural advantage over defense: fabricating a fake is quick and cheap, whereas checking and correcting it takes time.

To be fully effective, fact-checking would have to meet three conditions:

- ***Spot** all disinformation.*
- ***Verify it** quickly enough.*
- ***Get its corrections** to people beyond those already convinced.*

The third condition is rarely met. A study of 54 million Facebook users showed this: roughly two-thirds of the "likes" on fact-checks came from users who already mostly followed science pages, not from those who followed conspiracy pages (Zollo et al., 2017). *Corrections therefore mostly reach those who do not need them.*

Hence the need for the other pillars, which act on supply, on demand, and on the place of reliable information.

A paradox to acknowledge: effectiveness versus strength of evidence

The map below places the fifteen interventions from Table 1 of *La Désinformation* according to two criteria: their expected effectiveness (vertical axis) and the strength of the studies that evaluate them (horizontal axis). It reveals a mismatch. **The best-documented interventions are those with the most modest effects** (bottom right: well proven, but modest); **the most decisive are the hardest to prove** (top left: decisive, but poorly proven).



● Pillar 1 · Drying up supply ● Pillar 2 · Immediate causes ■ Pillar 3 · Deep causes ● Pillar 4 · Quality information

DITP INTERVENTIONS (LETTERS RANKED BY EFFECTIVENESS) AND THE MATCHING LEVER OF THE BRIEF

- **A** Support and revitalize the regional daily press (lever 13)
- **B** Ensure stable media funding and guarantee independence (lever 14)
- **C** Strengthen public integrity (lever 9)
- **D** Support other content producers (lever 16)
- **E** Support and equip the fact-checking sector (lever 16)
- **F** Reinvest in spaces of social connection (lever 10)
- **G** Strengthen social, economic and public-health policies (lever 11)
- **H** Media and information literacy (lever 5)
- **I** Inoculation (prebunking) (lever 6)
- **J** Clean up the digital space and promote reliable information (lever 1, 3)
- **K** Fact-checking (lever 7)
- **L** Display the source and its reliability (lever 8)
- **M** Introduce a reflective pause (lever 8)
- **N** Change recommendation algorithms (lever 2)
- **O** Display the source to equip the reader (lever 8)

Source: Table 1 of *La Désinformation* (Darcy, 2026), adapted from the DITP-VIGINUM report (2026). Colors: the four pillars of the brief.

This mismatch is no accident:

- **Testing the effect of a fact-check** on a belief is easy: show the correction to one group and not to another, then compare.
- **Demonstrating that a local news policy** makes a community less vulnerable is much harder, not least because of the cost: in the United States, an ambitious revival of local media has been costed at between $10 billion and $52 billion per year (Bateman and Jackson, 2024), a scale at which no one runs a controlled experiment.

As a result, public action that funded only what has been proven would inevitably invest in the least powerful levers.

The portfolio strategy

The literature converges on a **"portfolio strategy"** (Bateman and Jackson, 2024). The image is borrowed from finance: a prudent investor does not put everything into a single stock, but combines investments with different returns, risks, and time horizons. Applied to disinformation, it means **combining the four pillars** rather than searching for a single remedy, each playing a different role in the portfolio.

1 SUPPLY · SHORT TERM

Drying up the supply of disinformation

Cut off revenue, scrutinize platforms, track fake accounts. Indispensable against organized campaigns, but bypassed as soon as those spreading disinformation switch channels.

2 IMMEDIATE CAUSES · SHORT TERM

Addressing the immediate causes of belief

Media literacy, prebunking, pauses before sharing. Rapid, well-measured effects, but modest, and they fade over time.

3 DEEP CAUSES · LONG TERM

Addressing the deep causes of belief

Public integrity, social ties, material security. The deepest effects, but the slowest and the hardest to demonstrate.

4 QUALITY INFORMATION · MEDIUM TERM

Supporting quality information

Local news, stable media funding, equipped intermediaries. The pillar judged most effective, and the one that receives the least investment.

Three reasons justify this combination:

- **The pillars complement one another.** Learning to recognize a reliable source (pillar 2) is useless if no reliable sources are left to turn to (pillar 4). Removing content from a platform (pillar 1) does not remove the need that drove people to look for it: that need moves elsewhere, and only pillar 3 tackles it. Finally, structural policies take years to produce results, and protection is needed in the meantime.
- **Uncertainty is high.** As in finance, diversification guards against misdiagnosis: we do not yet know which lever matters most, or in which context.
- **Time horizons differ.** Short-term measures (pillars 1 and 2) respond to the urgency of an election or a crisis; structural measures (pillars 3 and 4) build resilience for the decade ahead.

Yet the formula has something disappointing about it: a balanced portfolio does not mean equal shares. Today, public action devotes most of its resources to pillars 1 and 2, the most visible and least costly, and too little to pillars 3 and 4, even though they are judged most decisive. **Rebalancing the portfolio** means agreeing to fund also what is hard to prove, provided it is evaluated over time. This is precisely the role of an observatory.

The Observatory of the information environment

A portfolio has to be managed: to rebalance it, one needs to know what works. Yet a survey of 106 French counter-disinformation practitioners (Darcy and Altay, 2026, *Harvard Kennedy School Misinformation Review*) reveals a twofold gap:

- **The field lacks** the necessary metrics.
- **It knows little** of what research has found.

The article sketches, on an exploratory basis, a **permanent observatory of the information environment** to fill both gaps. It is the concrete form of the brief's cross-cutting condition: giving ourselves the means to know.

55%

of practitioners consider the lack of shared indicators a serious obstacle. Institutions count what is easy to count (campaigns detected, content removed): they therefore see only supply, never demand.

71% / 36%

71% of practitioners trust research published in scientific journals, but only 36% keep up with it. And 88% read about disinformation mainly in French, whereas research is published mainly in English: they trust work they do not read.

A measurement unit

Measuring what current tools leave invisible

- **A recurring survey** of the same sample of citizens, on exposure to disinformation, beliefs, trust, and isolation. It would be run by INSEE, France's national statistics institute, under statistical confidentiality: no state-affiliated body would hold the beliefs of identified citizens.
- **Measures of the information supply**: number of journalists covering each area, funding for news, trends in trust.
- **Platform data**, which Article 40 of the DSA (the EU Digital Services Act) now allows vetted researchers to obtain, to see how falsehoods actually circulate: which accounts amplify them, how fast, and to whom.
- **Evaluation of programs** already funded. Ideally through random assignment (comparing a group that receives the program with one that does not); otherwise through "quasi-experimental" methods, which compare similar groups when random assignment is impossible. Standardized reviews would follow every major incident.

A translation unit

Getting research to those who act

- **Open-access syntheses in French** on the questions that keep coming up (does fact-checking work? how much are people actually exposed to disinformation?).
- **Profession-specific products**: a legal brief for the regulator, a threat brief for the analyst, a classroom resource for the teacher.
- **Knowledge brokers**: people tasked with relaying research within teams. They would be assigned where research culture is weakest, since that is the only setting where the main trial on the subject found them effective.
- **Regular feedback on indicators**: each institution would receive its results, compared with those of similar institutions and accompanied by an action plan.

The decisive point is that measures of **demand** (trust, isolation) would appear in the same instrument, at the same frequency, as the tally of foreign campaigns. We diagnose what we measure. Today, institutions count only detected campaigns and removed content, that is, supply; they conclude that the problem lies mainly in supply. Putting the two series side by side would correct this bias on its own.

THREE RULES TO MAKE IT LAST

- **Fund it once and for all** (through an endowment or a multiyear commitment written into law) rather than renegotiating its budget every year.
- **Give it public-law status**: if it is sued, the state then takes responsibility for its legal defense, rather than the body alone.
- **State clearly what it will never do**: no content flagging, no arbitration of true and false, no operations during election periods, no data sharing with security services.

Precedents show what threatens this kind of body. The Stanford Internet Observatory, a US research center, closed in 2024. It had moved from measuring the information environment to flagging election-related content; it was then hit by congressional subpoenas and lawsuits, whose defense cost the university dearly.

The proposed observatory could therefore not be created by decree: it would be built in stages.

- **First**, bring together existing efforts around a few shared indicators.
- **Then**, turn this into an institution only if the work bears fruit.

The authors present it as one avenue among others, not as a guaranteed solution. It answers a paradox: the field must combat a phenomenon it cannot measure, with knowledge it does not read.

Main sources: G. Darcy, *La Désinformation*, La Découverte, "Repères" series, 2026 (Chapter V and Table 1) · DITP and VIGINUM, 2026 · Bateman and Jackson, *Countering Disinformation Effectively*, Carnegie Endowment, 2024 · Darcy and Altay, "Disinformation in practice," *Harvard Kennedy School Misinformation Review*, 2026 (Appendix J) · Zollo et al., 2017.

Contact : gregoire.darcy@protonmail.com